

Children's Participation & Rights Policy

HIQA NATIONAL STANDARDS 2018 — STANDARDS 1 & 2 · UN CONVENTION ON THE RIGHTS OF THE CHILD

Chosanta Management is committed to ensuring that every child and young person in our care has a genuine, meaningful voice in decisions affecting their life and care. This is not a paper exercise — it is a lived reality underpinning everything we do.

Legislative & Regulatory Basis: UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (UNCRC) · Child Care Act 1991 · Children First Act 2015 · HIQA National Standards for Children's Residential Centres 2018, **Standard 1 (Children's Rights)** and **Standard 2 (Children's Needs)** · Tusla Child and Youth Participation guidance

1 CORE PRINCIPLES

- ✓ **Voice:** Every child has the right to express their views, feelings, and wishes — and to have these taken seriously in all decisions affecting them
- ✓ **Influence:** Children's views must demonstrably influence decisions about their care — not just be recorded and ignored
- ✓ **Access to advocacy:** Every child must know they can access an independent advocate and must be given information about how to do so at admission and at every care plan review
- ✓ **Accessible complaints:** The complaints process must be explained in plain language at admission and displayed visibly in the home
- ✓ **Privacy & dignity:** Every child has the right to privacy, to be treated with dignity, and to have their cultural, religious, and personal identity respected
- ✓ **Right to refuse:** Children have the right to say no to participation activities — participation must never be coerced

2 HOW WE HEAR CHILDREN'S VIEWS

Method	Frequency	Who Is Responsible	How It Is Recorded
Key worker 1-to-1 check-in	Weekly	Keyworker	Key worker log / daily notes
Resident house meeting	Monthly	PIC / Senior Staff	Resident Meeting Minutes
Care plan review — child's input	Every 4–6 months or as required	Social Worker + PIC	Care plan participation record
Feedback / suggestion box (anonymous)	Ongoing	PIC reviews monthly	Feedback log
Advocacy organisation referral	On request / at admission / concern	PIC	Advocacy referral record
HIQA / Tusla inspection — child interview	During inspections	Inspector	Inspection report

3 INDEPENDENT ADVOCACY

Every child must be informed of their right to independent advocacy at admission, at each care plan review, and at any point they request it. The following advocacy services are available to children in our care:

Organisation	Role	Contact
EPIC Ireland (Empowering People in Care)	Independent advocacy for children in care — free and confidential	epiconline.ie · 01 872 7661
Ombudsman for Children	Independent investigation of complaints about services affecting children	oco.ie · 01 865 6800
Tusla Duty Social Worker	Child's allocated or duty social worker — first point of escalation within the care system	Via local Tusla office

4 RESIDENT HOUSE MEETING — MINUTES TEMPLATE

Date	Chaired By	Minutes By
Children Present	(Initials only — maintain privacy)	
Staff Present		

Topic Discussed	Children's Views / Feedback	Action Agreed	Owner	Done?
House rules / routines				☐
Food / menus				☐
Activities & outings				☐
Any concerns / issues				☐
Actions from last meeting				☐
Other items raised by young people				☐

PIC Review: _____ Date: _____ Next Meeting: _____

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SECTION 2: CONSULTATION FORMS & FEEDBACK SYSTEMS

5 CHILD CONSULTATION FORM

To be completed by keyworker with the child — not by the child alone. Use plain language. Adapt for age and communication needs. Child does not have to answer any question they don't want to.

Child Ref / Initials	Date	Keyworker
Purpose of Consultation	☐ Care plan review ☐ Placement review ☐ House meeting ☐ Routine check-in ☐ Other	

Question	Child's Response (in their own words)
How are you feeling about living here right now?	
Is there anything you'd like to change about your daily routine or the house?	
Do you feel safe here?	
Is there a member of staff you feel you can talk to if you're worried?	
Is there anything in your care plan you'd like to talk about or change?	
Do you know how to make a complaint if you're unhappy?	☐ Yes ☐ No — explained today
Do you know you can speak to an advocate who is independent of this service?	☐ Yes ☐ No — EPIC info given today
Is there anything else you want us to know?	

Actions arising from this consultation:

Child's signature (if they wish): _____ Keyworker: _____ Date: _____

This form is stored in the child's file. A copy is given to the child if they wish. Contents shared with social worker at next review.

6 FEEDBACK & SUGGESTION LOG

Date	Feedback / Suggestion Received	Source	Action Taken	Outcome Shared Back?
		☐ Child ☐ Family ☐ Anon		☐ Yes ☐ N/A
		☐ Child ☐ Family ☐ Anon		☐ Yes ☐ N/A
		☐ Child ☐ Family ☐ Anon		☐ Yes ☐ N/A
		☐ Child ☐ Family ☐ Anon		☐ Yes ☐ N/A

7 ANNUAL PARTICIPATION REVIEW

The PIC must conduct an annual review of children's participation, evidencing how children's views have influenced care practices and service decisions during the year:

Area	Evidence of Children's Influence This Year
House routines / rules	
Activities / outings programme	
Food / menus	
Staff practices	
Care planning	

Legislative Basis: UNCRC · Child Care Act 1991 · Children First Act 2015 · HIQA National Standards 2018 (Standards 1 & 2) · Tusla Child and Youth Participation Guidance

Advocacy: EPIC Ireland — epiconline.ie · 01 872 7661 | Ombudsman for Children — oco.ie · 01 865 6800

Ref: CM-CPP-001 | Version 1.0 | May 2025 | Review: Annual | **Policy Owner:** PIC